12–15 Youth Football · 8-Week Home Gym Plan

Games still happen. The home work is there so they last the season.

3 sessions a week. 30–40 minutes. Almost no gear. Print it, clip it to the fridge. They train. You keep the stop-now list.

Written by Ryan Ambrosia, a football dad. ExpertRating certifications: Strength and Conditioning Training, Youth Fitness Trainer, Sports Nutrition (2025). It is the same plan I already run at home with my son and his football friends.

Space: a garage, driveway, basement, or any 10×10 floor.

Before you start (read once)

Check with their doctor first. Talk to your child's doctor before they start this or any new exercise program, especially after an injury, an illness, or a concussion. Tell their football coach or athletic trainer they are doing it, so home work and practice do not stack up.

If they have a current injury, a doctor's restriction, are in concussion protocol, or you are unsure: **they do not start.** Get cleared first.

This is a home movement and strength plan for healthy athletes ages 12–15 who already play football. It is not medical advice, a diagnosis, physical therapy, or a combine or weight-cut program. Use it with an adult present, at your own judgment and risk.

Not a shop product. Nexus Fit is a separate side project. This plan is not a product, service, or advice of any auto repair business.

Stop now (athlete)

They **sit** and you **end the session** if any of these show up:

- Sharp pain (not the normal burn of hard work).
- Dizziness, nausea, or they "see spots."
- Joint swelling they did not have when the session started.
- Any headache after a game, a practice, or a contact week. They sit. This is not a push-through day.
- They cannot control the movement, or the last rep looks like a different exercise.

Soreness the next day can be normal. Sharp pain during a move is not.

Never in this plan

- No 1-rep max. No "see what they can bench."
- No depth jumps or box jumps.
- No neck loading. No partner neck bridges. No helmet-on resistance.
- No "play through sharp pain."
- No steroids, no "research chems," no "just a cycle," no fat burners. If someone at school is selling that story, this plan is the other door.

How to use this

You (the parent) print it. They (the athlete) do the sessions. You watch the first two reps of every move.

- **3 days a week with a rest day between.** Example: Mon / Wed / Fri, or fit it around practice. Never three days in a row.
- **Practice and games count.** A heavy contact week means a lighter home week. Do not stack this on two-a-days and call it toughness.
- **Never on game day,** and not the day before a game. Use Session C or rest.
- **Leave 2–3 reps in the tank.** Every set should end with "I could do a couple more." No grinding, no failure sets.
- **Same five tests** at the start, week 4, and week 8. Write the numbers. Do not chase a record.
- **If a rep looks ugly, they regress.** Ugly reps do not count and do not build anything.

Who keeps what: you keep the stop-now and red-flag pages. They keep the session log.

Equipment

- Floor space with nothing to trip on.
- One resistance band (loop band or long band with a door anchor).
- Optional, weeks 5–8 only: a backpack with a few books, or one light dumbbell.
- Training shoes. No socks on a slick floor.
- Water and a phone timer.

No squat rack. No bench. No plyo box. No sled.

Safety notes

- **An adult is home and nearby** for every session, and watches week 1 in full.
- **Check the band every time.** Nicks, tears, or a worn spot: throw it out. Anchor it on the hinge side of a closed door that opens away from them, and tug-test it before the first rep.
- **Clear the floor.** No oil spots, cords, tools, or a car in the way. Good light.
- **Heat and hydration.** Hot garage or after a long practice: shorter session, more water, or skip it.
- **Concussion.** If they are in a return-to-play protocol, follow their doctor's and school's plan, not this sheet.
- **Pain is a stop sign, not a test.** Sharp or joint pain ends the move. Pain that is still there the next day means a rest day and a call to their doctor if it lasts.

Warm-up (every session, 6 minutes)

Do this before every session, including test days. Easy pace. It is not a workout.

Move	Dose	Cue
March in place, then skip in place	60 sec	Tall, opposite arm and leg
Arm circles, small to big	10 each way	Slow, shoulders down
Bodyweight squat to comfortable depth	8 slow	Heels down, knees track over toes
Hip hinge with hands on hips	8 slow	Hips back, long spine
Walking lunge or split-stance rock	5 / side	Front knee over the middle of the foot
Band pull-apart (light)	10	Squeeze the shoulder blades
Incline push-up on a wall or counter	5	Body one piece
Plank	20 sec	Breathe

Cool-down (3 minutes): easy walk, 30 seconds each: hip-flexor stretch per side, hamstring stretch per side, child's pose. No bouncing.

Week grid

Week	Job	Load	Speed
1	Learn the six moves. Baseline tests on day 1 or 2.	Bodyweight. Light band.	Skip / march only
2	Same moves, cleaner reps.	Bodyweight. Band.	Skip / march
3	Add a set if every set in week 2 looked like the first.	Bodyweight. Band.	Skip / march
4	Re-test the same five tests. Lighter week.	Nothing extra on test day.	Skip / march
5	Strength step. Backpack only if weeks 1–4 were clean.	Light backpack, slow reps	Wall march **if Gate 1**
6	Same. Small step up if week 5 was clean.	Add a book, not a stack	Wall march if Gate 1. Falling start **if Gate 2**
7	Same. Hold form.	No new load this week	Falling start only if Gate 2
8	Lighter week. Re-test at the end.	No hero day	Optional, only if gated

Gate 1 (wall march, weeks 5–8): a quiet bodyweight squat to the same depth every rep, a long-spine hinge, and a skip that is not a stumble. **Gate 2 (falling start):** a clean wall march. If a gate is not met, they stay on skip / march. Speed work is optional. It is not the point of this plan.

Contact week rule: a game or a hard practice in the last 48 hours means Session C or rest. Do not make up a missed session with a fourth day.

Progression: how they earn the next step

- **Reps first.** When every set of a move looks clean for **two sessions in a row**, add 1–2 reps per set next time, up to the top of the range.
- **Then a set.** At the top of the rep range, add one set (weeks 3 and 5–7 only).
- **Then load (weeks 5–8 only).** A few books in a backpack, worn on both shoulders or hugged at the chest. Add a little at a time, and only after two clean sessions. Never on the neck.
- **Step back any time.** A bad sleep week, a hard practice, or ugly reps: go back to last week's numbers. That is the plan working, not failing.

The six moves (foundations)

Teach these in week 1. Every session is some mix of them.



Squat
heels down, knees track over toes



Hinge
hips back, long spine



Incline push-up
body one piece, sturdy surface



Band row
pull to ribs, anchor holds



Plank
straight line, breathe



March
tall, opposite arm and leg

Move	Easier (regress)	The standard	Harder (only when earned)
Squat	Squat to a chair, tap and stand	Bodyweight squat, heels down	Backpack hugged at chest (wk 5+)
Hinge	Hands on thighs, short range	Hips back, long spine, hands on hips	Light backpack at chest (wk 5+)
Push	Wall push-up	Counter or table incline	Floor push-up, if 10 clean incline
Row	Light band, two hands	Band row from a door anchor	Slower 3-second return, or thicker band
Plank	Plank on knees	Forearm plank, straight line	Longer hold, never past 40 sec
March	March in place	Skip in place	Wall march (Gate 1)

Write one line the first week: which version they used. That line is the program.

Session A: Lower + brace (30–40 min)

Warm-up first. Rest 60–90 seconds between sets, longer if they need it.

Move	Weeks 1–4	Weeks 5–8
Bodyweight squat	3 × 8	3 × 8–10. Backpack only if squats were clean.
Hip hinge	3 × 8	3 × 8. Light backpack at the chest, not on the neck.
Split-stance hold (lunge position)	2 × 20 sec / side	2–3 × 20–30 sec / side
Plank	3 × 20 sec	3 × 20–40 sec
Skip or march	2 × 20 sec	2 × 20 sec, or wall march if Gate 1

If the last rep does not look like the first, the set is over.

Session B: Upper + brace (30–40 min)

Warm-up first. Rest 60–90 seconds between sets.

Move	Weeks 1–4	Weeks 5–8
Incline push-up (or floor if earned)	3 × 5–8	3 × 6–10. Stay on incline if floor reps break.
Band row	3 × 8	3 × 8–10
Dead bug (opposite arm and leg, low back down)	2 × 6 / side	3 × 6 / side
Side plank (knees down is fine)	2 × 15 sec / side	2–3 × 15–25 sec / side
Band pull-apart (light)	2 × 8	2 × 10

No bench press. No max set. If one side cannot match the other, both sides use the easier version.

Session C: Short mixed + speed basics (25–35 min)

Use it as the third day, on a tired week, or within 48 hours of a game. Warm-up first.

Move	Weeks 1–4	Weeks 5–8
Squat	2 × 8	2 × 8
Hinge	2 × 8	2 × 8
Incline push-up	2 × 6	2 × 8
Band row	2 × 8	2 × 8
Plank	2 × 20 sec	2 × 20–30 sec
Speed basics	Skip / march 3 × 15 sec	Skip / march by default. Wall march 3 × 10 sec only if Gate 1. Falling start 3–4 easy reps only if Gate 2.

Wall march (Gate 1 only): hands on a wall, body in one straight lean, drive one knee up at a time, slow and controlled. Not a race.

Falling start (Gate 2 only): stand tall on flat ground, lean forward until they have to step, and take 3–4 quick, easy steps. No stopwatch. If they dive or flail, go back to wall march.

Tests: the same five, three times

Fresh day only: not after practice and not after a session. Do the warm-up first. Count only clean reps. If form breaks, the set ends, and that number is the score.

Test	How to score	Start	Wk 4	Wk 8
1. Bodyweight squat	8 reps. Pass / fail on same depth, heels down.			
2. Hip hinge	8 slow reps. Pass = long spine. Fail = rounded back.			
3. Incline push-up	Same surface every time. Clean reps, one set.			
4. Band row	Same band, same anchor. Clean reps, one set.			
5. Plank	Seconds until hips sag or they hold their breath. Stop at 60.			

Skip / march is the sixth look (20 seconds): write "smooth," "rushed," or "stumble." It is not scored. It decides Gate 1.

Do not add a broad jump, a 40-yard dash, or a max lift to "make it real." That is how kids get hurt at home.

Parent page

You are not their strength coach. You are the adult in the room with the sheet. That is enough.

Sleep. School nights matter more than any set. A 10:30 pm session followed by five hours of sleep does more harm than good.

Water. A bottle at every session. Not a gallon challenge.

Food. Regular meals and snacks, with some protein at meals they already eat. No cutting, no bulking, no "shred" talk, no supplements unless their doctor says so. This plan does not include a meal plan.

Keep it theirs. Praise showing up and clean reps, not numbers. If they want a week off, that is fine.

Red flags: stop the plan and call their doctor

- A limp that lasts past the next morning.
- Pain at night that wakes them.
- Fever with joint pain.
- Weakness on one side, a foot that drags, or an arm that will not stay up.
- Headache, confusion, vomiting, or unusual sleepiness after contact. That is medical care today, not a rest-day swap.
- Chest pain, fainting, or being out of breath far beyond the work.

You do not diagnose from this page. Call their doctor. For chest pain, fainting, or confusion, call 911.

What you do not do: push them into a max squat, add box jumps because a video said "athletes explode," or let a teammate or older sibling "spot" them into heavier weight.

A note from me

I wrote this down because it is what my son and his friends already do at home, and most of what kids find online is max-outs and highlight drills. This is what we actually do: the basics, done clean, three times a week, with rest days and an adult watching. If they show up for 10 of the 12 sessions in weeks 1–4 and the test reps look cleaner in week 4, it is working. Questions: nexusfit86@gmail.com. — Ryan

Session log: weeks 1–4

#	Date	A / B / C	Minutes	Stop-now?	Notes (version used, how it looked)
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					

Session log: weeks 5–8

#	Date	A / B / C	Minutes	Stop-now?	Notes (version used, how it looked)
13					
14					
15					
16					
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					

Re-test on a fresh, non-session day at the end of week 8. If it is unsafe that day, they sit. Games still happen. The home work is there so they last the season.